

Edmund Burke's Notion of Beauty & Sublime

ENG110: Literature for Life

Beauty

ation and love. The sublime, which is the cause of the former, always dwells on great objects, and terrible; the latter on small ones, and pleasing; we submit to what we admire, but we love what submits to us; in one case we are forced, in the other we are flattered into compliance. In short, the ideas of the sublime and the beautiful stand on foundations so different, that it is hard, I had almost said impossible, to think of reconciling them in the same subject, without considerably lessening the effect of the one or the other upon the passions. So that attending to their quantity, beautiful objects are comparatively small.

“A deceitful maze”

yet the whole is continually changing. Observe that part of a beautiful woman where she is perhaps the most beautiful, about the neck and breasts; the smoothness; the softness; the easy and insensible swell; the variety of the surface, which is never for the smallest space the same; the deceitful maze, through which the unsteady eye slides giddily, without knowing where to fix, or whither it is carried. Is not this a demonstration of that change of surface continual and yet hardly perceptible at any

beauty—a theory more reminiscent of German aestheticians such as Alexander Gottlieb Baumgarten and Moses Mendelssohn than of any of his British contemporaries—that ‘so far is perfection, considered as such, from being the cause of beauty; that this quality, where it is highest in the female sex, almost always carries with it an idea of weakness and imperfection. Women are very sensible of this; for which reason, they learn to lisp, to totter in their walk, to counterfeit weakness, and even sickness’ (III.ix). We do not know what Burke’s own wife, sturdy enough to outlive him by fifteen years, thought of this bit of sexism, but even at the time many male commentators found this view absurd, as have many of both sexes since.

But if the sublime is built on terror, or some passion like it, which has pain for its object; it is previously proper to enquire how any species of delight can be derived from a cause so apparently contrary to it. I say, *delight*, because, as I have often remarked, it is very evidently different in its cause, and in its own nature, from actual and positive pleasure.

Sublime

- “..is conversant about terrible objects, or operates in a manner analogous to terror is sublime” (p.33)
- satisfied with the idea that the pain is much more elusive and gratifying than the idea of pleasure
- The central idea was that the experience of the sublime is an ‘elevation of mind’ or ‘transport’, a ‘vehement and inspired passion’, but produced in response to ‘great conceptions’ or representations of human greatness.

Sublime

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fhHcty9OM-0&list=RDfhHcty9OM-0&start_radio=1&pp=ygUQZXJvaWNhIGJIZXRob3ZlbqAH AQ%3D%3D
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aEHlgjoueeg&list=RDaEHlgjoueeg&start_radio=1&pp=ygUclEJhY2JigJlzlFN0IE1hdHRoZXc gUGFzc2lrbqAHAQ%3D%3D
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bc6aG09SqwU&ab_channel=MythicalKitchen (Infinity is scary)

...

- Burke then argues that our pleasure in the sublime is simply our **delight at pain threatened but avoided**, and is thus stimulated by all sorts of terrifying things as long as they do not actually injure or destroy us, while our positive pleasure in beauty is stimulated by properties that we find sexually attractive or that invite non-sexual companionship. (xv)

Art Pieces

- <https://www.tate.org.uk/art/art-terms/s/sublime>
- <https://www.metmuseum.org/perspectives/sublime-northern-romantic-painting-christen-sveaas>